

06 - Dragon Codex

Project: Dragon Merchant Guild (*Working Title*)

Document Version: 1.0

Status: Core Worldbuilding Document

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1. Purpose

The Dragon Codex establishes the universal rules governing every dragon species within the Dragon Merchant Guild world.

It does **not** describe individual species.

Instead, it defines the biological, ecological, behavioral, and design principles that every dragon must follow.

Whenever a new dragon is created, it should naturally fit within the framework established by this document.

Think of this document as the world's biology textbook rather than its encyclopedia.

2. Design Philosophy

Dragons are animals first.

The world's dragons are not magical tools created for human convenience.

They are living creatures with their own instincts, needs, and ecological niches.

Humans did not create dragons.

Humans merely learned to cooperate with them.

Guilds adapt to dragons.

Rather than breeding dragons to perform jobs, merchant guilds historically observed what dragons naturally excelled at and organized work around those strengths.

A mining dragon does not exist because humans wanted a miner.

Humans discovered that a certain species instinctively excavated underground tunnels, then built mines around that behavior.

This philosophy applies to every species.

Every dragon has a purpose beyond work.

Even dragons with obvious guild uses should make sense in nature.

A dragon should still feel believable if no humans existed.

If removing humans from the world causes a dragon to lose its reason for existing, its design should be reconsidered.

3. What Is a Dragon?

Within this world, dragons are one branch of large reptilian megafauna.

While their appearances vary greatly, all dragons share several defining characteristics:

- Highly adaptable metabolism.
- Exceptional spatial memory.
- Strong territorial instincts.
- Long lifespans.
- Social learning abilities.
- Highly specialized evolutionary niches.

Not every dragon flies.

Not every dragon breathes fire.

Those traits belong only to certain lineages.

4. The Dragon-Human Relationship

Dragons are partners.

They are neither livestock nor machines.

Successful guilds understand that dragons willingly cooperate because the partnership benefits both sides.

Guilds provide:

- Food
- Shelter
- Safety
- Medical care
- Social interaction

Dragons provide:

- Labor
- Transportation
- Protection
- Specialized ecological skills

Healthy partnerships create loyal dragons.

Poor treatment results in stress, reduced productivity, or abandonment.

5. Dragon Intelligence

Dragon intelligence varies between species.

Most dragons possess intelligence comparable to highly capable social animals.

They can:

- recognize individuals,
- learn routines,
- remember locations,
- solve practical problems,
- communicate through body language and vocalizations.

Some species are naturally more curious.

Others rely almost entirely upon instinct.

Dragons are intelligent enough to cooperate.

They are not intended to function as human replacements.

6. Domestication

Most dragons are not truly domesticated.

Instead, they are considered **guild-trained**.

Guild training emphasizes cooperation rather than obedience.

Training develops:

- trust,
- familiarity,
- communication,
- predictable routines.

Wild dragons and guild dragons remain biologically identical.

Only their experience differs.

7. Instincts vs Learned Behaviors

One of the most important design principles is the distinction between instinct and training.

Instinct

An instinct is an inborn behavior.

Examples include:

- digging toward underground vibrations,
- following river currents,
- collecting shiny minerals,
- maintaining body temperature,
- nesting in elevated terrain.

Instincts exist regardless of human influence.

Learned Behaviors

Guild dragons gradually learn routines through repeated experience.

Examples include:

- carrying cargo,
- responding to whistles,
- recognizing feeding schedules,
- returning to assigned shelters,
- working alongside specific workers.

Guild work should almost always build upon existing instincts rather than replacing them.

8. Ecological Classification

Every dragon belongs to exactly one ecological class.

This describes where it naturally fits within the world's ecosystems.

Current classifications include:

Burrowers

Specialists in underground environments.

Common characteristics:

- powerful forelimbs,
 - reinforced skulls,
 - excellent vibration sensing.
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Forest Dwellers

Adapted to dense woodland.

Traits often include:

- camouflage,
 - climbing,
 - quiet movement.
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River Dragons

Adapted to freshwater ecosystems.

Often possess:

- streamlined bodies,
 - excellent swimming ability,
 - water-sensitive senses.
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Marsh Dragons

Adapted to wetlands.

Commonly resistant to disease and poor environmental conditions.

Highland Dragons

Found in rocky mountains.

Adapted for steep terrain and thin air.

Coastal Dragons

Live near oceans.

Often migrate seasonally.

Desert Dragons

Adapted to heat and scarce water.

Grassland Dragons

Fast-moving species suited to open terrain.

Additional ecological classes may be added as the world expands.

9. Guild Profession Classification

Unlike ecological classes, profession classifications are human inventions.

A single dragon may serve multiple professions.

Current professions include:

- Mining
- Forestry
- Agriculture
- Construction
- Transport
- Courier
- Water Management
- Fishing
- Surveying
- Exploration
- Hospitality
- Smithing
- Security

- Waste Management
- Research

Profession categories describe how humans use dragons.

They do not define the dragons themselves.

10. Dragon Lifecycle

All dragons progress through several life stages.

Hatchling

Dependent.

Learning.

Curious.

Requires constant care.

Juvenile

Increasing independence.

Rapid growth.

Highly playful.

Ideal age for guild socialization.

Adult

Physically mature.

Capable of professional guild work.

Most dragons spend the majority of their lives in this stage.

Elder

Reduced physical ability.

Greatly increased experience.

Often serve as teachers for younger dragons.

11. Temperament

Every dragon possesses an individual personality.

Species influence temperament but never fully determine it.

Possible personality traits include:

- Curious
- Timid
- Protective
- Playful
- Patient
- Stubborn
- Competitive
- Gentle
- Independent
- Affectionate

Individual differences help dragons feel alive rather than interchangeable.

12. Dragon Needs

Every guild dragon shares five fundamental needs.

Nutrition

Proper food.

Rest

Adequate sleep and recovery.

Enrichment

Mental stimulation.

Exploration.

Play.

Social Bonding

Interaction with compatible dragons and trusted humans.

Health

Medical care.

Injury treatment.

Disease prevention.

Neglecting any need should eventually affect behavior rather than simply lowering a numerical statistic.

13. Dragon Welfare

Merchant guilds are evaluated partly on dragon welfare.

Well-cared-for dragons:

- recover faster,
- cooperate willingly,
- perform consistently,
- develop trust.

Poor welfare should create believable consequences.

Examples include:

- refusing dangerous work,
- becoming withdrawn,
- reduced efficiency,

- increased illness risk.

The goal is realism rather than punishment.

14. Dragon Bonding

Every dragon gradually develops familiarity with workers.

Repeated positive interactions increase trust.

High trust enables:

- easier training,
- better cooperation,
- reduced stress,
- greater reliability.

Trust cannot be purchased.

It is earned over time.

15. Dragon Design Principles

Every newly created dragon should satisfy the following checklist.

1. Ecological Purpose

Where does this species naturally live?

2. Survival Strategy

How does it survive without humans?

3. Instinct

What natural behavior defines the species?

4. Guild Utility

How did humans discover a practical use for this instinct?

5. Trade-Off

Every dragon should have at least one meaningful weakness.

Perfect dragons are poor designs.

6. Care Requirements

What makes this dragon difficult—or rewarding—to care for?

7. Personality

What kinds of personalities are common?

8. Merchant Value

Why would a merchant guild invest in this species?

9. Future Expansion

What additional mechanics could later deepen this species?

16. Dragon Creation Template

Every future dragon entry should follow this structure.

Species Name

Scientific Name (*optional*)

Ecological Class

Guild Profession(s)

Habitat

Diet

Temperament

Primary Instinct

Guild Application

Strengths

Weaknesses

Care Difficulty

Worker Compatibility

Merchant Value

Daily Routine

Interesting Behaviors

Developer Notes

Future Expansion Ideas

17. Naming Conventions

Species names should describe observable characteristics rather than mythical grandeur.

Preferred examples:

- Stonejaw Drake
- Hearthscale Drake
- Riverveil Drake
- Mosshorn Drake
- Emberback Drake
- Ironcrest Drake

Avoid overly elaborate fantasy names unless they serve a specific cultural purpose.

The world should feel practical.

Merchant guilds tend to use descriptive names that are easy to remember.

18. Future Expansion Philosophy

The Dragon Codex intentionally avoids specifying exact species.

Species belong within the separate Bestiary.

This allows the world to grow indefinitely without changing its underlying biological rules.

Every future dragon should reinforce the world's internal consistency.

The objective is not simply to create interesting dragons.

The objective is to create a believable ecosystem where every dragon feels as though it could have evolved naturally and where every guild profession emerged by observing, respecting, and cooperating with those natural instincts.

Closing Statement

A dragon should never exist because the game needs a mechanic.

The mechanic should exist because someone learned to work alongside the dragon's natural behavior.

This principle should guide every future species added to the Dragon Merchant Guild world.